central employer, accounting for 35 per cent of these jobs. But it's no exception to the general laggardly trend in hiring. In 2019, then railway minister Piyush Goyal had announced that the PSU would hire over 400,000 people by 2021. But the RRB made only 134,220 recruitments in 2019-21. The anger gets bottled up: the 12.5 million job-seekers who had applied for those 35,281 railway jobs, hundreds of whom blew their fuse in Bihar's small towns, had already waited over two years for their results.

The same reluctance to hire is visible elsewhere. The armed forces—the No. 2 central employer, with 14 per cent jobs—have 122,555 vacant posts. That includes nearly 10,000 officers' posts. (Don't even begin to think of what this implies in terms of 'efficiency'.) And a total of 41,177 posts are lying vacant in public sector banks. The Centre often blames budgetary constraints, but the numbers don't entirely support such claims. Central expenses on all pay and allowances, including for civilian and armed forces, have indeed grown by 50 per cent between 2015 and 2020, but if you compare that to its share of GDP, the rise has been minuscule—from 1.09 per cent to 1.6 per cent.

If the Centre doesn't hold...

Do the states? Central employment constitutes only around 14 per cent of India's public employment. The rest is controlled by the states—but we have no real quantification of how much 'the rest' adds up to. It's likely a highly fluctuating figure, no one keeps a real count, and whatever partial data there is happens to be well-guarded. But if we assume a ballpark figure of 28-30 million, and extrapolate the general trend towards vacancies, we can safely posit a few million possible jobs lying empty. The All-India State Government Employees Federation (AISGEF) says there are 3 million vacancies in the states and UTs. Tragically, though not unexpectedly, the states are doing no better at filling those. In FY 2021, states saw a total of 389,052 recruitments—a drop of 107,000 from the previous fiscal, and in sync with a general, gradual slide. In 2018-19, states created a total of 542,504 jobs—a little over 45,208 per month—according to the Union ministry of statistics and programme implementation. In 2019-20, that number dropped to 496,003, or 41,333 per month.

The Rajasthan government, on which the CMIE confers the dubious distinction of having the highest 'unemployment rate' (18.9 per cent) among states, claims to have made 101,164 recruitments in the past three years, but still has 200,000 more vacancies to fill up! Compare that to the four-fold rise in the number of unemployed graduates in the past four years—of Rajasthan's 6.5 million unemployed youth, 2.06 million are graduates.

What of UP? Well, state budget documents reveal 400,000 vacant posts under various departments. Yet, the results of over 20 recruitment exams—conducted by the state's Subordinate Services Selection Commission (UPSSSC), to fill up nearly 30,000 posts—have been pending for the past five years. Alleged irregularities mean most of the exam procedures are pending in court. In fact, 21 exams held in



PAWAN BHAWAR

MADHYA PRADESH

Ranjeet Raghunath, 26, *B.Sc. (Agriculture)*

Job applied for: Agri Extension Officer in MP

Total vacancies: 863; Total applications: 22,000

Ranjeet, a resident of Dawatha village in Madhya Pradesh's Dewas district, earned a bachelor's degree in agriculture in 2017. Ever since, he has been preparing for entrance tests for government jobs in the agriculture sector. In February 2021, he appeared for the test organised by the MP Professional Examination Board (MPPEB), more commonly known as Vyapam, for recruitment as rural agriculture extension officer, a class IV appointment under the state government. Following rumours of a paper leak and